ANNOTATOR GUIDELINES · VERSION 1 · 24 SEPTEMBER 2026

Forced Alignment

French fr_FR

How to use this guide. Parts 1–4 apply to all languages. Part 5 has the French rules; where they differ from Parts 1–4, Part 5 wins.

Pending = not final yet; this guide will be updated.

1. Your task
2. Segment rules
3. The tool
4. Writing the text
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6. Checklist before you submit

1 · Your task

Each task is one audio file that a machine has already cut into word segments. Every segment has a **start time**, an **end time** and the **text of one word**. The machine makes mistakes: check every segment and correct it.

1. Listen to the audio.
2. Check every segment: **timing** — does it start and end exactly with the word? **Text** — is it exactly what was said, written the way this guide says?
3. Fix every error: move edges, correct the text, split, merge, add or delete segments.
4. Answer the two task questions: more than one speaker? Overlapping speech?
5. Discard the task if a discard reason applies (2.6).
6. Submit.

2 · Segment rules

2.1 What one segment is

French: one segment = one space-separated word. Elided forms stay whole (l'homme = 1 segment). Details: Part 5.

2.2 Boundaries

- Start the segment where the word's sound begins. End it where the sound stops.
- End where the **speech** stops, not where the waveform ends. If the tail is silence or noise — even if you still see amplitude — pull the edge back to the last real speech. Same at the start.
- In fluent speech words blend and there is often no silence between them. Listen carefully and use judgment to find where one word ends and the next begins.
- A segment whose start and end are equal (zero length) is an error: give it the word's real length.
- **Segments from the same speaker must never overlap.** Overlap is allowed only between different speakers (2.4).

2.3 What to fix

PROBLEM	FIX	EXAMPLE
Segment starts too early or ends too late	Move the edge	Starts 40 ms early → move the start to the word's onset
Zero-length segment	Give it its real length	Start = end → extend the end

PROBLEM	FIX	EXAMPLE
Wrong text	Correct the text (Part 4)	Type the word that was actually said
One segment holds two or more words	Split: one segment per word	`il y a` → `il` `y` `a`
Letters said one by one are joined	Split: one segment per letter	`tf` → `t` `f`
A filler sits inside another word's segment	Split	`je` → `euh` `je`
One word is spread over several segments	Merge into one segment	—
A spoken word has no segment	Add a segment	—
Segment covers only silence or background noise	Delete it	Segment over silence → delete it; add the word where it is really said
Segment covers only a cough, laugh, breath or other non-word sound	Delete it	—

2.4 Speakers and overlap

For every task, answer: **Is there more than one speaker? Is there overlapping speech?** In the tool: *Multi-speaker* and *Overlap speech* (Part 3). Overlapping segments must belong to different speakers.

2.5 Special cases

Entirely synthetic speech (text-to-speech)

- Mark it only when you are confident the **whole file** is computer-generated. Leave the transcription empty. In the tool: dustbin button (top right).
- Signal: a perfectly fluent, native-sounding voice that makes mistakes a fluent human would not — mispronounced words, misread numbers or abbreviations, stress on the wrong part of a word.
- Mistakes by a non-native speaker or a child are normal human speech — not a signal.
- Not sure? Do not guess — transcribe it.
- Human and synthetic speech in one file (e.g. a person talking to a bot): do not mark it. Transcribe normally and set the synthetic speaker's **Nativity** to **TTS**. Pending where Nativity is set in the tool.

Garbled or distorted part (you cannot tell whether it contains words)

- Not pre-segmented → leave it; add no segments there; transcribe the rest normally.
- Pre-segmented, **fewer than 20** segments in that part → delete them, add **one** segment `(())` covering the part, continue with the rest.
- **20 or more** segments in that part → discard the whole task.

Unintelligible and guessed words

- Speech you cannot make out → `(())`. A guess → the guessed word in double brackets: `((télévision))`. Whole file unintelligible → discard.
- Misspoken non-word, but you know or can guess the intended word → the intended word in double brackets. Use sparingly — only when what was said has no correct spelling.
- Only for the main speakers. Never transcribe background speech.

Another language in the audio

- Transcribe and segment it if you can, with that language's normal spelling (script rules: Part 5). Its presence alone is not a reason to discard.
- If you cannot transcribe or segment any part of it — even a small part — discard: *Non-target language*.
- Never transcribe other-language speech in the background.

2.6 Discard

In the tool: dustbin button (top right), then choose one reason from the drop-down.

Audio not loading · UI Issue · No audio · No voice activity · Non-lexical sound only · Non-target language · Sensitive content · Unintelligible

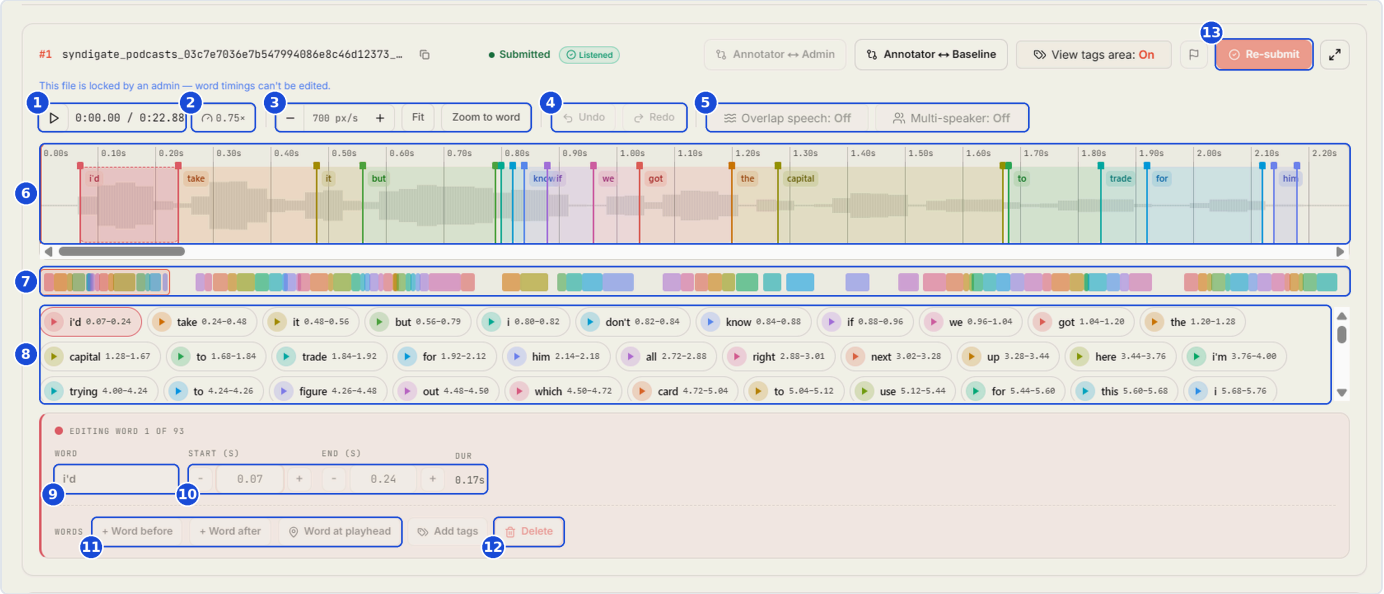
SITUATION	REASON
Audio is distorted or garbled; no intelligible speech	Unintelligible
Only cross talk (no main speaker, or the main speaker is unintelligible because of it)	Unintelligible
Main speaker entirely unintelligible — only `(())` possible, not even guesses	Unintelligible
Only humming or other non-word sounds; no words	Non-lexical sound only
Sensitive content	Sensitive content
Other-language speech you cannot transcribe or segment	Non-target language
The file contains only an extremely cut-off word	Discard — reason Pending
Garbled part with 20 or more segments	Discard — reason Pending

Pending

- Where to cut at a liaison (in *les amis* the "s" is said as "z" at the start of *amis*). Until this is settled, listen carefully and use judgment (2.2).
- Which discard reason to choose for the two cases marked Pending above.
- Where a speaker's Nativity (TTS) is set in the tool.

3 · The tool

All languages use the same tool.



#	CONTROL	WHAT IT DOES
1	Play ▶ and time	Plays the audio; shows current time / total length.
2	Playback speed	Speed of playback (here 0.75×).
3	Zoom − / +, Fit, Zoom to word	Zoom the waveform in or out, fit it to the view, or zoom to the selected word.
4	Undo / Redo	Undo or redo your last change.
5	Overlap speech / Multi-speaker	Turn on when speech overlaps / when there is more than one speaker. Adds a speaker layer to the timeline, where you assign each segment to Speaker 1 or Speaker 2.
6	Waveform	Each coloured block is a segment. **Drag its left or right edge** to change its start or end.
7	Overview strip	All segments in the file at a glance.
8	Word list	Every segment with its start–end time; ▶ plays it. The highlighted one is being edited.
9	Word	Text of the selected segment. Edit it to correct the text.
10	Start / End (s), Dur	− / + nudge the start or end time. Dur is the segment's length.
11	+ Word before · + Word after · Word at playhead	Add an empty segment before or after the selected word, or add a segment where the playhead is.
12	Delete	Removes the selected segment.
13	Submit (top right)	Submits the task. Shows "Re-submit" here because this file was already submitted.

Not in the screenshot: the **split** and **merge** buttons · the **dustbin** button, top right (discard, or entirely synthetic speech) · the speaker layer (appears when 5 is on) · keyboard shortcuts (listed in the tool).

How to do each fix

TO…	DO THIS
Change a start or end	Drag the segment's edge on the waveform (6). Fine-tune with − / + next to Start or End (10).
Correct the text	Select the segment and edit the Word field (9).
Split a segment	In the Word field, put a space at each split point (`il y a`), then press the split button. You get one segment per space-separated part. Drag each new segment's edges into place.
Merge segments	Use the merge button to join the pieces into one segment. Then check its text and both edges.
Add a missing word	Select the word next to it and use *+ Word before* or *+ Word after* — or put the playhead on the word and use *Word at playhead* (11). Type the word, then drag its edges.
Remove a segment	Select it and press *Delete* (12).
Mark speakers or overlap	Turn on *Multi-speaker* and/or *Overlap speech* (5), then assign each segment to its speaker in the new layer.
Discard the task	Dustbin button (top right); choose the reason from the drop-down.
Mark entirely synthetic speech	Also through the dustbin button (top right).
Undo a mistake	*Undo* / *Redo* (4).
Finish	*Submit* (13).

4 · Writing the text

4.1 Basics

- **Spoken form:** write what the speaker actually said, as they said it — not a cleaned-up written version.
- **Latin letters:** always lowercase.
- **No punctuation**, except: an apostrophe that is part of a word (`l'homme` · `c'est`); a hyphen marking a cut-off word (`télévi-`); an optional period after a spelled letter (`t. f.`).
- **Numbers:** always as words, never digits. Write the number in its standard written form, remove hyphens, and give each space-separated word its own segment. Examples: Part 5.
- **Spelling:** the reference dictionaries in Part 5.

4.2 Hyphenated words

- Remove the hyphen; each part is its own segment: `grand-mère` → `grand` `mère` · `quatre-vingt-sept` → `quatre` `vingt` `sept` .
- This applies to all hyphenated words, including names, places and brands. Only exception: the hyphen that marks a cut-off word.

4.3 Cut-off words and self-corrections

- Write as much of the word as you hear and put the hyphen where it is cut: `télévi-` (end cut off) · `-vision` (start cut off). The cut-off word gets its own segment around the part you can hear.
- Only slightly clipped but fully audible → write the whole word, no hyphen (`télévision`).
- Do not add a hyphen to a complete word just because the audio starts or ends there.

- The file contains only an extremely cut-off word → discard.
- Self-correction that cuts a word → hyphen: `mets cette chan- chanson`.
- Repetition or correction without a cut → no hyphen: `c'est c'est bon` · `appelle julie non je veux dire juliette`.
- Interrupted while spelling letters → write only the letters said. No hyphen after a period.

4.4 Letters and acronyms

- Letters said one by one → one segment per letter; a period after each letter is optional: `t` `f` or `t. f.`.
- Acronym said as a word → one segment: `otan`.
- One-letter words of your language are words, not letters: no period (Part 5 lists them).

4.5 Fillers and backchannels

- Fillers (euh, ben) and backchannels are words: each gets its own segment. Multi-part ones are split: `mm hm` → `mm` `hm`.
- Use the French spellings in Part 5.
- Coughs, laughs, breaths and humming get no segment.

4.6 Homophones

Choose the spelling from context. If the word is said on its own, choose the one more likely to be said on its own.

4.7 Names and brands

Same rules as everything else: lowercase Latin, hyphens removed, letters split when spelled out. Examples in Part 5.

5 · French rules

fr_FR

One segment = one space-separated word. Elided forms are one word → one segment; the apostrophe stays: `l'homme` `j'ai` `d'accord` `c'est` `qu'il`.

Dictionaries	Larousse (larousse.fr) → Le Robert (lerobert.com) → Merriam-Webster for English words.
Letters	All lowercase. Keep all accents: **é è ê ë à â î ï ô ù û ü ÿ ç**.
Elision (mandatory)	l' · j' · d' · n' · qu' · m' · s' · c' before a vowel: l'amie · j'aime · d'abord · n'est pas · qu'elle · m'a dit · s'il te plaît · c'était.
Colloquial forms	Write as heard: chépa (je ne sais pas) · t'sé (tu sais) · y'a (il y a) · ben (bien) · ça — when said, write ça (do not change it to cela).
Numbers	Hyphens are removed, so every part is a segment: quatre-vingt-sept → `quatre` `vingt` `sept` (87).
Fillers & backchannels	euh · ben · bah · hein · bof · ouais · mm hm → `mm` `hm` · ah (surprise) · hmm
One-letter words	y (`il y a`) and à are words, not letters — no period.
Homophones	Use context: ver / verre / vers / vert · mère / mer / maire · sain / saint / sein · peut / peu.
Names & brands	`youtube` · `squeezie` · `cyprien` · `france` `télévisions` (keep accents) · TF1 → `t` `f` `un` or `tf` `un`, as pronounced.
Other languages	Keep the standard spelling of the other language (usually English). Arabic or other scripts: the original script if possible, otherwise the closest Latin transcription.

Pending

- The letter œ (cœur, sœur) is not in the list above yet; follow Larousse spelling until it is added.

6 · Checklist before you submit

- ☐ Every word has exactly one segment; elided forms (l'homme) are not split.
- ☐ Every segment starts at the word's first sound and ends at its last; no zero-length segments.
- ☐ No segment covers only silence, noise, coughs, laughs or breaths.
- ☐ The text matches what was said and follows Part 4 and Part 5.
- ☐ Multi-speaker and Overlap speech are set correctly; overlapping segments belong to different speakers.
- ☐ If the task must be discarded, or is entirely synthetic, you used the dustbin button.